

Julian Brush

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling owned an embarrassing student painting you have spent years trying to buy back. He planned to display it tonight beside your celebrated recent work as a joke about 'humble beginnings.'

What you are hiding

You have secretly used buyers to acquire several of your own early paintings so you could remove them from circulation. The art world would find that both vain and market-manipulative. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Daphne knows you were behind the anonymous buybacks.
- Persuade Celeste that the student painting should not be displayed.
- Avoid giving Morgan Slate a quote you will regret.

What you know about other guests

- Sterling owns one of your embarrassing student paintings and has been discussing displaying it.
- Imogen has been furious that the gala spectacle resembles an unreleased concept of theirs.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Cobalt pigment from your jacket appears on the drink tray because you signed a catalogue there earlier. During the poison window, the Registrar's copier records you scanning proxy-purchase paperwork connected to your secret campaign to buy back your own early paintings. The log clears your timing but exposes the buybacks.

IF MURDERER

At 6:44 you entered with a signed sketch for Sterling. You poisoned the cordial and wiped the glass, but a fleck of your distinctive cobalt studio pigment transferred from your cuff to the stem.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

Yes, I have been buying back my own early work. Vanity is legal. Sterling planned to humiliate me with a student painting, and I hated him for it. The Registrar's copier log shows me scanning the proxy-buyer paperwork throughout the poison window. I was hiding vanity, not murder.

IF MURDERER

Sterling thought ownership gave him the right to define me forever. He planned to turn my worst student painting into a punch line beside the work I fought to become capable of making. I brought him a sketch, poisoned the cordial, and wiped the glass. I missed one fleck of cobalt. Apparently every artist leaves a signature.